Staying Alive to the Possibilities of Becoming: Designing for Hope in Uncertain Futures

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Abstract
At the core of designing futures is 'possibility', not just predictability. While design has embraced a host of futures methods that explore what 'might' or 'could' happen, such as scenarios, there remains a tendency to ignore the discomfort that comes with embracing the unknown. A failure to attune to the tolerance for uncertainty of those involved, risks their aversion to the process and proposals of designing futures. The purpose of this research is to understand how designing futures can support actors in staying "alive to the possibilities of becoming" (Barad, 2007, p. 396), with particular regard to navigating their discomfort with uncertainty. Drawing on learnings from two attempts at designing futures within mental healthcare systems in Norway, this paper presents strategies for designing that premise future potentialities as situated within the thick, unfolding present. This research offers a pathway for stewarding emerging potentialities by working intentionally with time as nested and agency as relational to cultivate hope in uncertain futures.

Keywords
Futures
Uncertainty
Resistance
Relationality
Hope

Introduction

Amid growing popularity and uptake of futures methods, design is increasingly positioning itself as a means of exploring possible futures (Candy & Potter, 2019; Clèries & Morrison, 2020). Design is said to contribute to futures approaches by bringing rich, speculative visions to life so that others can understand what these possible futures could look like and feel like, often with the aim of informing the present-day strategy of organizations and communities (Candy & Kornet, 2019; Martinussen & Matthews, 2019). Acknowledging that designing futures rests in the space of possibility rather than predictability, unearths 'uncertainty' as a central element of such processes.

Research has highlighted that feelings of discomfort often arise in connection with exposing uncertainty and can significantly hinder the integration of learnings from participating in such processes (Brassett & O'Reilly, 2015; Ramirez & Selin, 2014). In particular, employees' resistance to change and attitudes towards uncertainty are well-documented as a major contributor to failed change efforts (Ahmad & Cheng, 2018; Rehman et al., 2021), especially in complex systems like health care (Nembhard et al., 2009). Ignoring these feelings and failing to attune to the tolerance of those involved for 'not knowing', risks compromising the utility and impact of efforts aimed at designing futures.

As such, the aim of this paper is to understand how efforts to design futures can support participants in staying open to unfolding potentialities, acknowledging their discomfort amid uncertainty. In response, this research draws on learnings from two practical explorations of designing futures within mental health systems in Oslo, Norway, through a collaboration between a Master of Design course and a local research hospital. These learnings are integrated with insights from Karen Barad's (2007) work on relationality to develop five strategies for staying "alive to the possibilities of becoming" (p. 396) when designing futures. Barad's work highlights the need for nurturing openness and responsibility among related actors amid ongoing change.

The five strategies identified include: 1) acknowledging causality as an entangled affair; 2) working from 'within' the world's becoming; 3) responding to manifold entanglements; 4) staying close to the pulse of the here and now, and 5) meeting the universe halfway. These strategies offer a pathway for stewarding emerging potentialities by working intentionally with time as nested and agency as relational when designing futures. In particular, this research shows the importance of cultivating the conditions for hope, where actors can take action and responsibility from within their existing entanglements to shape ongoing unfoldings toward preferred futures.

Background

To contextualize this research, we begin by providing a brief overview of the domain of designing futures, the risk of resistance within this work, and inspiration from Karen Barad (2007) to help frame this challenge.

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Designing Futures

The definition of design has long been linked to shaping futures (Simon, 1969; Banathy, 1996). In recent years, there has been a resurgence of interest in futuring in and through design (Clèries & Morrison, 2020), resulting in a stronger integration of design and foresight methods in practice (Candy & Potter, 2019). Scenario building is one of the most common futures methods used in design, which involves creating a fiction about what might or could happen (Willis, 2005). These future scenarios are often categorized as 'possible' — any futures that could exist, 'plausible' — futures that one could reasonably expect, 'probable' — futures that are likely to happen, or 'preferable' — the most desirable futures (Henchey, 1978).

Speculative design brings these futures to life through visualizations, artefacts and experiences, aiming to help those involved anticipate challenges and shape a more informed pathway forward (e.g. Candy & Kornet, 2019). In the context of speculative design, visualizations and artefacts play an important role in helping people grasp ideas about future possibilities that often stay abstract and feel far removed. In practice, this can take the form of a single artefact that integrates science fiction to tell the story about a future world, like in the work of the Near Future Laboratory (Bleecker, 2009), or fully immersive installations that invite visitors to build emotional connection and cultivate critical questioning about the future, such as in the work of Superflux (Jain, 2026).

Future methods, such as scenarios and causal layered analysis, are positioned as disruptors of current understandings that aim to support others in generating alternative worlds (Watson, 2009). By inserting futures into the present, these methods are thought to become attractors that influence the emergent direction of the present (Massumi, 2011; Brassett & O'Reilly, 2015). Sometimes these processes are participatory, where actors are invited into anticipating and imagining different futures themselves and then returning to challenge their own assumptions in the present, as through the work of Future Literacy Laboratories (UNESCO, 2023).

Risk of Resistance

Proponents suggest that "if we can imagine such worlds we can partially prepare ourselves for whatever future does come to pass. Confronting the future with rigor tends to leave most people energized and enthusiastic about facing their future — even if the future looks grim" (Kleiner, 1999, as cited in Willis, 2005, p. 5). This thinking suggests that exposure to future scenarios can help instill a sense of agency among actors in relation to shaping their future. Despite this compelling rationale, others highlight that an intolerance for ambiguity and resistance to alternative views within the mainstream is a significant reason why future scenarios fail to come alive in the minds of decision-makers and their staff (Hodgson, 2007).

Furthermore, there is recognition that future scenarios can bring discomfort amid uncertainty, which often results in futures being considered implausible or irrelevant, and a refusal to integrate knowl-

edge about such possibilities (Brassett & O'Reilly, 2015; Ramirez & Selin, 2014). Resistance to change remains a significant barrier when working to catalyse organizational and systemic change through designing futures, especially in complex systems (Rehman et al., 2021). Psychological factors such as status quo bias, loss aversion, and identity threat often lead individuals to resist the possibility of future changes that challenge existing norms or roles (Khaw et al., 2023).

When future scenarios present uncertainty and perceived risk, the resistance often intensifies, as people tend to favour familiar structures over ambiguous alternatives. Scenarios are also critiqued for often reflecting huge speculative leaps that are difficult to relate to present realities (Curry & Mulligan, 2025). Amid recognition that futures methods need to be better situated in present realities, new methods and approaches, such as futures landscapes, are being experimented with (Curry, et al., 2024). Instead of fragmented scenarios, the landscapes approach explores the emergent and adjacent possibilities of interconnected domains, or sub-systems, looking across the near future, thick present and recent past (Curry et al., 2024). Even with such alternative methods, there is a need to understand how best to situate futures amid the plural, ongoing becoming of the present and how to navigate the discomfort with uncertainty that can render such efforts ineffective.

Relationalities of Becoming

To aid in framing this unwieldy challenge, we turn to Karen Barad's (2007) work on agential realism which offers deep attention to uncertainty amid the entanglements of the past, present and future. They highlight that "there is no [...] exterior position where the contemplation of [...] possibility makes any sense. We are of the universe-there is no inside, no outside. There is only intra-acting from within and as part of the world in its becoming" (Barad, 2007, p. 396). This suggests the importance of situating the process of designing futures as forever already in motion, as possibilities for becoming are remade in the intra-actions of each moment.

Acknowledging existing entanglements, Barad makes an ethical call for "being alive to the possibilities of becoming" and stresses that ethics involves "accountability for the lively relationalities of becoming of which we are a part" (p. 396). With this framing, the challenge then becomes: How can designing futures promote inter-acting responsibly 'within' ongoing unfoldings by taking into account pre-existing relations in many directions? Given the challenges with regard to actors' resistance to the unknown, there is a need to better understand the necessary considerations for carefully attuning to the role that those involved play in the world's becoming and their capacity for navigating and cultivating more desirable potentialities.

Methodology

Framed by inspiration from Barad (2007), this research aims to understand how efforts to design futures can support actors in staying "alive to the possibilities of becoming" (p. 396), with particular regard to navigating their discomfort with uncertainty. This research is conducted

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using an abductive research-through-design approach, which aims to elicit tacit knowledge from the process of designing (Frayling, 1993; Cross, 1999). In this research, tacit knowledge was drawn from two practical explorations in designing futures within mental health systems as part of educational and research collaborations between two masters-level service design classes at The Oslo School of Architecture and Design (AHO) and Oslo University Hospital (OUS) in Norway.

The tacit knowledge involved in this process was drawn in through the reflections, observations and participation of the authors of this paper — two design researchers and teachers from AHO and two physicians and medical researchers from OUS. The first and third authors supported both practical explorations and the second and fourth author joined the research process to co-facilitate the second practical exploration. In addition, this tacit knowledge was strengthened with the integration of theory (Friedman, 2008) from design futures literature (e.g. Clèries & Morrison, 2020; Candy & Potter, 2019) and literature on agential realism (Barad, 2007), which was found to offer a useful theoretical framing for related learnings. To support this integration, this research followed an abductive process of "sequencing", which involves moving between design practice and theory (Redström, 2017).

Empirical Context

Mental health issues constitute one of the most significant public health challenges in Norway, accounting for more than 20% of total absence due to illness (Norwegian Directorate of Health, 2024a). Since the 1980s, Norway has undergone a process of decentralization and deinstitutionalization within mental health services, with a dramatic decline in the number of hospital beds and an increase in outpatient services (Norwegian Directorate of Health, 2024b). At the same time, there has been an increase in requests for mental health services, particularly among young people (Norwegian Ministry of Health and Care Services, 2023). There remains a substantial gap between the mental health services currently provided and the population's actual needs. Consequently, mental healthcare is one of the most important priority areas of the Norwegian national government.

Norway has among the highest number of psychiatrists and psychologists per capita of any country in the world (Reitan & Lien, 2023), but as Norway is a large country with a dispersed population, there are huge variations in the availability of specialists. Although Norwegian physicians traditionally report high levels of overall job satisfaction, longitudinal data indicate a significant downward trend, particularly among hospital-based doctors and those working in the public sector (Rosta et al., 2019). Concurrently, there are increasing reports of unsatisfactory working conditions characterized by excessive workload and reduced professional autonomy, with documented negative consequences on both mental and somatic health among physicians (Engen, 2025). This has made it important to incorporate strategies for how to retain and recruit clinicians within public mental health services.

In shaping the future, the current 10-year national government plan (2023-2033) prioritizes accessibility of services, prevention, lowering thresholds for receiving help, and greater attention to personnel

resources (Norwegian Ministry of Health and Care Services, 2023). While the integration of digital tools in mental health is recognized as promising to address existing challenges, the implementation of such tools remains limited within the Norwegian context (Romm et al., 2025), and may also contribute to creating new uncertainties (Petrakaki et al., 2025). As mental health services are currently undergoing a period of significant transition in Norway, this constitutes a particularly fruitful empirical context for studying the process of designing futures.

Practical Explorations

This research began by exploring alternative possibilities for the future of mental health services in Norway through a seven-week collaboration with four hospital-based clinical teams. In particular, the design students were invited to bring to life possible futures informed by different alternative logics influencing mental health services, such as a market-, state- or community-based logic (Nilsson et al., 2022; Sangiorgi et al., 2022). These future scenarios 30 years into the future were informed by a signal and trend analysis based on media and related literature on mental health services, 15 interviews with system actors, observations within the four clinical teams, and a half-day workshop focused on the present-day logics in each service, led by the service design students.

These inputs enabled the identification of key drivers of change and potential shifts in logics. This, in turn, set the analytical framework for four divergent future worlds, in which present-day mental health services were reimagined to achieve strategic fit with each scenario. The process culminated in the staging of four experiential future scenarios (Candy & Dunagan, 2017; Candy & Kornet, 2019) in the old patient rooms of an unused wing of a local mental health hospital Fig. 1. A final half-day workshop, in which clinical staff and leaders were invited to participate in the experiential scenarios as well as follow-up conversations, revealed a discomfort around what was emerging within these scenarios and resistance to the utility of such an approach in relation to their everyday work.



Fig. 1
Experiential future scenario exploring the future of mental health services (Designed by Chen Huang, Samuele Sala Veni and Eline Mikhela Olsen Sandnes. Photo by Enrique Encinas).

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The discomfort and resistance emerging from participants in the first exploration, led to adjustments being made in the second exploration into designing futures. The second practical exploration aimed to illuminate actionable and preferable future possibilities for digitization across mental health services in the hospital. To frame this exploration, we adopted the futures landscapes approach, inspired by Curry et al. (2024). The visual framework developed to guide the adoption of the futures landscapes approach is shown in Fig. 2. It depicts the integration of the 'near future' — close possibilities that could happen in the next five years, the 'thick present' — an understanding of the complexity and multiplicity of the current time, which includes the overlap of past and future, as well as the 'recent past' — what has just come to pass in the last five years. Fig. 2 also shows an emphasis on emergent and adjacent possibilities; and attention to interconnected domains, or sub-systems, rather than fragmented scenarios.

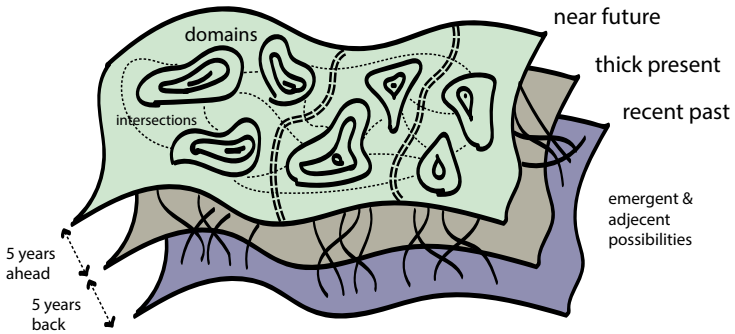


Fig. 2
Visual framework of Futures Landscapes (Illustration by the Authors, inspired by Curry, Warwick and Vallantyne, 2024).

This second exploration of designing futures involved seven weeks of collaboration, including 35 interviews, regular coaching sessions with internal champions, and a half-day workshop with hospital practitioners to define inter-related domains that would be a focus. Working closely with system stakeholders connected with each of the domains, the students identified emergent near-future possibilities for digitization (5 years ahead) and explored the implications. This exploration culminated again in a half-day workshop with stakeholders from throughout the hospital focused on shaping desirable emerging, near future possibilities for the seven identified domains connected with the digitalization of mental health services Fig. 3. The basic approach of each of these two practical explorations into designing futures is outlined and compared in Tab. I.



Fig. 3
Futures landscapes workshop exploring possibilities for digitization in mental health services (Photo by Josina Vink).

	Exploration 1	Exploration 2
Aim	Explore alternative possibilities for the future of mental health services in Norway	Illuminate actionable, preferable future possibilities for digitization across the mental health system in Oslo
Futures framework	Experiential scenarios (Candy & Dunagan, 2017)	Futures landscape (Curry et al., 2024)
Duration	7 weeks	7 weeks
People Involved	Clinical staff, design teachers, design students	Broad system stakeholders, internal champions, design teachers, design students
Participation	15 interviews, observations of units, conversations with clinical leads, 1 half-day workshop, 1 full-day workshop	35 interviews, coaching sessions with internal champions, 1 half-day workshop, 1 full-day workshop
Futures Scope	4 existing hospital services (forensic follow-up, referrals for addition, trans magnetic simulation treatment and old age psychiatry)	7 identified domains (e.g. opening-up patient choice, digital infrastructure for monitoring, employee and leadership education, driving economic benefits)
Timeframe	Far future - 30 years ahead	Near future - 5 years
Year conducted	2023	2025

Tab. I
Overview of the two practical explorations into designing futures.

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Abductive Analysis

After these practical explorations were complete, a critical comparative analysis of the implications of the two explorations was conducted through reflection and dialogue among the authors, using notes, archival materials and personal experiences of participation. Through this analysis, we identified significant tensions related to dealing with uncertainty and some emerging strategies for working with, rather than ignoring, related discomforts. This approach aligns with an abductive approach of "identifying mysteries", in which noticing where the empirical material deviates from expectations based on theory is used to help advance the current knowledge base in a way that it is both novel and practical (Alvesson & Kärreman, 2007). Here we paid particular attention to places where we struggled in practice, which were not well accounted for in the existing literature on designing futures.

To address these observed shortcomings in the existing design futures literature and support the development of strategic responses to these struggles, we found resonance and inspiration in Karen Barad's (2007) work on agential realism. In particular, their ethical call to stay alive to the possibilities of becoming at the end of their book *Meeting the Universe Halfway* aligned with our ambitions and grappled with similar tensions in working across temporalities. Through a process of systematic combining (Dubois & Gadde, 2002), we integrated learnings from this new theoretical input, our practical insights, and reflections on existing design futures literature into five strategies for staying alive to the possibilities of becoming. In this way, theory on agential realism helped to provide a language and framing for the strategies that emerged from our empirical analysis.

Strategies for Staying Alive to the Possibilities of Becoming

The following five strategies for designing futures address the question of how to support actors in honouring their responsibility by staying alive to the possibilities of becoming. Leveraging insights from Barad (2007), along with learnings from our practical explorations, we draw considerations for carefully positioning such practical efforts.

Acknowledging Causality as an Entangled Affair

A central concept in Barad's (2007) work is that of intra-action, which denotes the mutual constitution of entangled agencies. Through the term intra-action, Barad suggests that there is no such thing as individual agency that pre-exists a situation, rather the ability to act emerges through relations. Through this conceptualization, Barad also radically challenges the traditional idea of causality, suggesting that the way things move in systems is not simply cause and effect. When designing futures, this means that creating future visions does not in and of itself enable people to act on them, but rather there is a need for "attending to the political possibilities for change" (Barad, 2007, p. 34).

The first attempt at bringing to life possible mental healthcare scenarios, which were 30 years into the future, brought together clinicians from different hospital units and exposed them to what these participants perceived as radical possibilities beyond the present day. In the empty wing of the hospital, these clinicians visited the possible futures of all clinical teams, not just their own, and together engaged in collective dialogue about what they had seen. Through this shared experience, which brought together clinical leaders, doctors, nurses and some administrative support staff, we were able to facilitate a shift in collective consciousness about the open-endedness of the future, and for some participants, widen the horizon of their imagination about the future of these services.

While creating reference points for possible long-term directionalities, weaving together both desired and un-desired ones, the staging of these scenarios did little to ground the action of participants in the present and acknowledge how the agency of those participating was entangled with other actors and systems in the hospital and beyond. It provoked strong reactions and resistance among some of the hospital staff involved, highlighting the limitations around political possibilities for action at that time within the hospital. Still, this widening of the collective consciousness about future possibilities helped to set some groundwork for the second exploration, which was then able to attend further to specific entanglements of agency in the thick present around key themes.

Working From 'Within' the World's Becoming

Barad (2007) reminds us that there is no exterior position from which to design futures. As such, we cannot assume the position of the 'perfect modest witness' observing the world; rather we are always 'of' the universe, performing it by intra-acting from within. This highlights an important learning from our explorations: the design work needs to be tethered to ongoing unfoldings from the outset, rather than positioned as an outside input and then retrofitted onto present day realities at a later date.

While in the first exploration there was an agreement with hospital leadership for collaboration, the focus of the futures work remained with the service design students, who conducted fieldwork and then developed far-future scenarios based on their learnings. The agreement for collaboration masked a fundamental difference in the interpretation of taking on a future orientation. Staff and hospital leadership alike were taken by surprise — it simply had not occurred to them that anyone might be thinking on that timescale and allow themselves to think so speculatively. In creating the future scenarios, the students also drew on a variety of trends and inputs outside of the direct contexts, sometimes due to the limited input they received from the professionals involved or to their direct access to local contexts. When clinical staff were then invited to experience the scenarios, it left them with 'homework' to do to figure out how to connect their experience and emerging thoughts back to their daily life. Ultimately, due partly to the time

pressures the staff were already under, some participants came to feel that this process of designing futures was largely irrelevant to their daily work.

In the second exploration, internal champions initiated the process of designing futures from within and framed the work within a pressing internal mandate around digitization. These champions carefully supported connections from the inside, coaching the design students through the process. They helped to convey the lived realities of the ongoing transition and aided the students in positioning their designing futures work as amplifications of emergent possibilities, always left unfinished, to be co-designed with the participating system actors. Being positioned more closely to the inside of the ongoing becoming, led to participants feeling that they were already part of the unfolding futures. At the same time, the near future timeframe, focused only five years ahead, and the direct connection to an existing hospital mandate, may have also limited the horizon of becoming that was considered within this work.

Responding to Manifold Entanglements

Challenging the value and even existence of fragmented futures, Barad clearly articulates that: "not even a moment exists on its own. "This" and "that," "here" and "now," don't pre-exist what happens but come alive with each meeting" (p. 396). For Barad, responsibility in bringing forward futures "entails an ongoing responsiveness to the entanglements of self and other, here and there, now and then" (p. 394). They provide grounding for a way of designing futures that maintains the many strings attached in various directions and acknowledges the interconnectedness of being.

When bringing forward four divergent scenarios in the first futures exploration, participants were immersed in speculative moments with limited context regarding how such moments came into being. Each of these scenarios was inspired by present day signals of change, extrapolated and skewed into different possibilities. These scenarios were also framed in relation to a particular hospital unit, siloed based on existing organizational divisions and missing the connections between the scenarios and across the system. These scenarios were perceived as critical provocations, even "wild cards" or "dark swans" (Mehrabanfar, 2014), although this more extreme interpretation was far from the intent of the designers. Participants expressed struggling with feelings of hopelessness amid the vast uncertainty they were exposed to.

Alternatively, in the second exploration the futures work was initially framed by a broad group of systems actors based on themes that cut across clinical and administrative units in the hospital in relation to digitization. By deliberately working within the nearby, forward, backward and sideways building connections and learnings between different domains, the futures possibilities explored together maintained the many existing threads between and across time and space. The domains did not take for granted the behind-the-scenes aspects of the unfolding futures but worked head-on with nuance around the intricacies of transcending issues

such as economy Fig. 4. Many of the participants in the final workshop of the second exploration stated in their reflections that they felt a surprising sense of hopefulness emerging, not out of the inevitability of desirable futures, but because they could see the mobilization of collective action to shape the ongoing unfolding.



Fig. 4
Exploring the interconnected economic issues of digitization in the near future (Designed by Helene Østmoe Aspeli and Tiril Andrea Eide Bennett. Photo by Josina Vink).

Staying Close to the Pulse of the Here and Now

Instead of seeing the future as an "end point of a set of branching chain reactions", Barad suggests that the future is "a cascade experiment", which is remade in each moment (p. 394). Their work disrupts traditional Western concepts of time, highlighting that "future moments don't follow present ones like beads on a string" (p. 394). Instead, "what seems far off in space and time may be as close or closer than the pulse of here and now that appears to beat from a center that lies beneath the skin" (p. 394). In this passage, we are reminded of the possibility of time traveling while staying close to the felt experiences and relations within.

One of the most effective aspects of the first exploration was the embodied experience of participants fully immersed in possible futures for mental health services within the different patient rooms. Fig. 5 shows one clinical team member role-playing the experience of receiving art therapy provided by the hospital within the public library thirty years into the future. This allowed them to feel their relation to a possible future under their skin in the present. Some participants highlighted their resonance with a movement to deliver what are now hospital-based services in the community in the future, which prompted continued efforts to adapt their approaches of service provision toward community follow-up. Yet at the same time, these scenarios — 30 years into the future — were so distinct from the present-day that they could be seen as 'other worldly', often with completely alternative aesthetics and few remnants of the past and present of mental health services remaining recognizable.

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Fig. 5
An immersive experience into trying out an alternative mental health service delivered in a local library 30 years into the future (Designed by Marieliz Morales Vega, Hala Barzan, Lilijean Comlan & Daphne Chan. Photo by Enrique Encinas).

In another way, the second exploration stayed close to the pulse of the here and now by shaping the leaping-off points within the futures landscapes based on shared tensions experienced in the present with regards to digitization. The prompts that the service design students then created were based on the futures that were currently being made and remade through ongoing negotiations across the hospital system in the present. For example, several domains explored the experiences of clinical staff in relation to conducting digital consultations and working from home, an active negotiation that was unfolding in the present between patients, clinical staff and hospital leadership. By following the evolving threads of existing tensions, this futures work showed how "the past is never finished once and for all" as Barad (2007, p. 394) wrote, weaving past legacies and present struggles into the discussions of near futures.

Meeting the Universe Halfway

In their ethical call, Barad (2007) highlights the importance of actors "meeting the universe halfway", which involves taking "responsibility for the role that we play in the world's differential becoming" (p. 396). This reinforces the importance of mobilizing those involved to see their own responsibilities and capacities act within their entanglements of the present-day unfoldings. Barad's work on the relational nature of agency does not negate the possibility for action but does imply the importance of working with the conditions for doing so and more collective approaches.

Based on this thinking, it is critical to stay close to where actors see they have a stake and scope for action in relation to the future becoming. Despite leaping off from present-day hospital-based mental health services, the explicitness of 'the stake' of participants was rather limited by the far-future time horizon of 30

years ahead, where some of the current clinicians commented that they would no longer be practicing. Experiencing these speculative scenarios, while thought-provoking perhaps in their attempt to reveal blind spots, did not immediately help those involved connect with their own role in shaping these futures. Here futures instead happened to them, when they opened the door to each new future enactment in the hospital wing.

In the second exploration, this meeting of the universe halfway was supported through greater participation of the system actors involved in shaping the future domains that were relevant to their own scope for action, sparking further motivation and intentionality for them to act within the ongoing becoming. The close involvement of participants throughout the process — particularly the internal champions and guides — contributed to building capability among the hospital actors around approaches to working with futures, rather than just insight into the shape of possible futures.

This active collaboration strengthened the elasticity of those on the inside of the becoming, to grapple with the ongoing intra-actions. The careful stewardship of the internal champions also helped prepare other hospital staff and leaders in setting expectations and possibilities for the collaborative process. This collaboration seemed to help foster a greater tolerance for working with and encountering uncertainty in everyday work, not with fear but with both intentionality and curiosity.

Discussion

Bringing reflections from these practical explorations into designing futures into conversation with Barad's work highlights the relational nature of agency in shaping futures across time and space. In terms of temporalities, this research emphasizes the unavoidable entanglement of actors in the thick present when exploring possible futures. Acknowledging this entanglement reinforces the importance of carefully situating futures work within the evolving happenings of actors' here and now, as well as understanding their shared imaginary, and its limits. Reminding us of the nested nature of time, Barad calls attention to the ways that futures emerge from pasts and presents, implying that these pasts and presents inform the relationship of actors to uncertainty amid their ongoing becoming. Furthermore, working consciously and collaboratively with located entanglements of the pasts and presents when designing futures seemed to cultivate a greater sense of responsibility and propensity for action, rather than resistance, among participants.

In addition, this research helps to explain the relationality of discomfort, and resistance among the actors involved to integrating lessons from futures explorations. In the context of healthcare, cultivating openness to change often requires attending to feelings of insecurity in relation to uncertainty, acknowledging difficulties with unlearning, as well as confronting the lack of organizational conditions for adaptation (Gupta et al., 2017; Cheraghi et al., 2023). Working simultaneously across time scales in healthcare demands recognition of the role of historical medical missteps, such as bloodletting and lobotomy, in shaping the collective imagination and contributing to a culture of caution, in which uncertainty and deviation from established norms are perceived to be professionally hazardous.

In addition, the reality of over-stretched and time-pressured clinical environments seemed to reduce the elasticity necessary to imagine doing things differently in the present, especially when this work was to be completed as individual 'homework' in isolation. Actors' capacity for future imagining is always inherently entangled in their pasts and presents.

Connecting with previous research on the thick present of futures work, this research reinforces that "actions, harmful or restorative, take place in the context of other actions, those already underway and those anticipated" (Sandford, 2023, p. 5). Indeed, this work reinforces the consideration that actions to bring about futures are not isolated but rather entangled in other movements across time and space. Aligned with Sandford, this research appreciates working with the thick present as an alternative to the unreliable future, while recognizing that the future is lived out and continuously renewed through action in the present, which refracts the past. Through this research, we learned that when designing futures in healthcare, long-term explorations and working with far-off scenarios may be useful to provide initial disruptions for opening-up and laying the groundwork for more near future explorations. At the same time, we learned that jumping ahead in one big speculative leap can enhance discomfort and hopelessness in those involved, given what they see as being already underway. Alternatively, we found that working closely with actors inside the hospital, slowly building trust among them, and supporting them in shaping their ongoing process of becoming more intentionally, was critical to bolstering their relational agency and collective sense of hope in relation to the future. In addition, designing futures with actors in relation to an internal digitization strategy within the hospital created a strong foundation for engagement and greater perceived relevance of the work.

This research suggests that there is a need to move beyond staging futures for actors to respond to, which are often separated from their histories and contexts, toward adopting more systemic, relational and place-based approaches to working with futures as becoming. Designing futures, then, is not just about bringing to life possible futures through stories, tangible artefacts or experiential scenarios, but also involves the important work of supporting actors to take responsibility for their part in the ongoing unfolding of futures. For designers, this demands acquiring a strong sensitivity to actors' collective conditions for change and working actively to create the capacity to imagine on the inside. Employing methods, approaches and models that work across time and space without separating them (e.g. Curry et al., 2024; Lin et al., 2025) may be one way to help resist disconnecting futures practices from other relational practices (Duan, 2023). In addition, based on learnings from this research, we highlight the need for greater levels of participation and collaboration among actors, not just in experiencing or being exposed to possible futures, but in shaping them for themselves, together.

This work opens a host of additional questions for future research. When designing futures, how do we understand the elasticity of entanglements in their ongoing becoming? What are helpful strategies for becoming attuned to the level of openness of actors and their contexts to embracing uncertainty when designing futures?

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How can we gently stretch the collective imagination, easing discomfort and avoiding provoking a sense of hopelessness? What new or adapted methods, approaches and models could help designers and other actors to work with the nested nature of time and the relational nature of agency when shaping futures? We need to continue to hold and explore these and other related questions that can help us respond to Barad's ethical call to stay alive to the possibilities of becoming. This is particularly critical amid the prevalence of despair and the general discomfort with uncertainty. We believe that design has a critical role to play in nurturing collective hope in relation to futures, not out of a naive understanding of optimism or ideal futures, but by nurturing and sustaining a shared sense of responsibility among actors for the role they play in shaping the ongoing becoming of the world.

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